



“No one ever doubted his [Sunil Mittal’s] intentions, capability, or leadership skills... He puts in a lot of hard work”

DEEPAK PAREKH

CHAIRMAN, HDFC LIFE
INSURANCE AND HDFC AMC



“It [the Airtel IPO] was difficult to market... but Mittal convinced the investors. Today, it is a very different company with enormous scale”

HEMENDRA KOTHARI

CHAIRMAN, DSP
INVESTMENT MANAGERS

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Delhi? With a grin, Mittal says Airtel’s risk-taking ability was greater when the company was small. “Today, there are a lot of committees, and I look back at what we went through with some disbelief,” he says. One example: when the fourth operator licences were up for bidding in mid-2001, Airtel had to decide whether to bid for Kolkata or buy incumbent Spice Cell. Spice Cell’s Dilip Modi was in the Airtel office late one evening and decided to close the deal that night. “We wrapped it up early in the morning before going home,” says Mittal. Buyouts followed in other regions. “By 2002-03, we started to ratchet up our presence. There were 12-13 mobile rollouts and another five or six from fixed lines apart from domestic and international long-distance and satellite nodes. Things got pretty tough since RCom came from nowhere,” recalls Mittal. Surviving that storm was a bigger miracle than the launch of Jio in 2016.

WHAT LIES AHEAD?

Airtel began eyeing Africa in 2008 and tried to buy South

Africa’s MTN Group, but that deal fell through. In 2010, Airtel acquired Kuwait’s Zain Group, which had operations in 15 countries in Africa. The \$10.7-billion acquisition, completed in 2013, gave Mittal a huge footprint, but Zain’s operations were steeped in losses. Mittal knew how to stop the bleeding, and it is profitable now.

Today, Airtel is at the forefront of the digital economy, says Deloitte’s Shetty. As 5G technology takes root, Airtel is everywhere: from manufacturing, mobility, and logistics to healthcare and IoT. It already has over 31 million 5G phones on its network, and Shetty sees a CAGR of 43.8% for India’s 5G market over 2023-31, to \$178 billion.

Then, there is OneWeb, a network of over 600 small satellites for communications, which Mittal calls the last frontier. About 2 billion people live in “dark radio areas” where there is no signal because it does not pay to set up towers there. But this dark area is also a huge market for satellite broadband, which Shetty says can grow 36% annually to reach \$1.9 billion by the decade’s end.

Satellite-based telephony services go back to the late 1990s when the Iridium satellite network made voice calls possible from any place on Earth. But Iridium sank under the cost of the satellites. Today, the world is watching OneWeb, which has put these communication satellites in orbit. “Just imagine them circling the globe in 12 planes at 25,000 km an hour and covering every square inch of land, water, and earth. That’s really powerful,” Mittal says enthusiastically. He believes the new service will complement mobile telephony, not replace it.

Mittal builds the trust of people around him. Parekh says people stick with him for years. “He puts in a lot of hard work.” Parekh recalls how Mittal reached out to him for someone to chair the audit committee. “I gave him two or three names, and he asked me, ‘Who would I take?’” Parekh suggested V.K. Vishwanathan, then with Bosch. “‘If you have recommended someone, it must be the right choice,’ Mittal said,” he recalls, adding that success has not gone to his head.

Success to Mittal means becoming more responsible. “Now, there are a lot of stakeholders. As the organisation’s founder, you feel a little heavier on the shoulders. I would let that be assessed by people who deal with me or work with me, though I personally feel that I remain more or less in the same orbit,” he says.

Winning in an industry where Airtel was given very little chance is a good feeling. “It was good to win against a very formidable force, and had I been in an industry without this kind of highs and lows, the joy of success would not have been at the same level,” he says. Without a doubt, Mittal is looking at another round of success. **BT**

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